

Parallelism & Sentence Connections

Study Guide - Language & Editing

1. Learning goal

Keep equivalent ideas in the same grammatical form and connect clauses so their logical relationship is clear.

2. What this skill means

Parallel structure makes lists and paired ideas easier to follow. Coordination joins ideas of similar importance; subordination shows that one idea depends on or qualifies another. Editing questions often test both form and logic at the same time.

3. Do not confuse it with

"The job requires checking labels, recording counts, and reporting damage" is parallel. "Checking labels, to record counts, and damage reports" is not. Also, and, but, because, although, and while do different logical jobs.

4. How GED-style questions may ask it

Questions may ask for the most parallel revision, the best way to combine two sentences, or the conjunction that expresses contrast, cause, addition, or condition.

5. Repeatable method

- Identify the items or clauses being connected.
- Decide whether they have equal importance or whether one depends on the other.
- Put items with the same job into the same grammatical form.
- Choose the conjunction that matches the exact relationship.
- Read the whole sentence aloud in your head to check balance and logic.

6. Worked example

The checklist asks workers to inspect the seal, record the temperature, and report any damage.

Question: What makes the list parallel?

Reasoning: All three items begin with base verbs after to is understood: inspect, record, report.

Best answer: The three actions use the same grammatical pattern.

7. Common traps

- Mixing nouns, -ing forms, and infinitives in one list without a reason.
- Using and when the sentence needs contrast or cause.
- Making one side of a paired construction much longer or structurally different from the other.

8. Diagnostic help

- If a list feels uneven, underline the first word of each item and compare their forms.
- If a conjunction question is difficult, name the relationship first: addition, contrast, cause, time, or condition.
- If not only/but also appears, check that the structures after both parts match.

Why this matters in ER: Parallel comparisons help an ER compare two arguments cleanly, and accurate conjunctions show how evidence connects to your reasoning.

9. Quick check

The pilot was inexpensive but difficult to schedule.

What relationship does but express?

Check yourself: But connects two equally important ideas while signaling contrast.